

U

zbekistan's Abdukodir Khusanov (**right**) has steadily built a reputation since joining Manchester City in January

2025, when he became the first player from his country to play in the Premier League. Just five months after that move, he was back in the headlines as the Central Asian nation booked a maiden ticket to the World Cup, with the 22-year-old central to the historic milestone.

The 6'1" centre-back featured in 14 (12 starts) of Uzbekistan's 16 Asian qualifying matches across three years, helping his side keep 10 clean sheets while losing just once and drawing five.

Over the months that followed, he earned the trust of his club manager, Pep Guardiola, becoming a regular at centre-back while also occasionally featuring at right wing-back.

While quiet and unassuming off the pitch, Khusanov has served his side well with crunching tackles and long-range passing, and has also emerged as one of the fastest defenders in the game. He has already secured the League Cup title in his first full season and is on the hunt for two more trophies.

Despite his age, Khusanov heads to the World Cup as one of the more battle-hardened players. And if he seeks further guidance for his role, he won't have to look further than the touchline, where he will be managed by World Cup- and Ballon d'Or-winning defender Fabio Cannavaro, who has hailed him as a leader for others to follow.

Abdukodir Khusanov

UZBEKISTAN

Age - 22

Club - Manchester City

Int. caps - 25